

Station 2: Studio cameras

Framing and composition on the studio bodies: shot sizes, angles, symmetry, look room, then two people: shot / reverse shot, over the shoulder, clean and dirty close-ups.

Where your shots go: The capture button sends each still to the wall. The shot-size ladder. Eye level, high, low. Canted. Centered vs. thirds. Look room right vs. wrong. The OTS pair. Clean vs. dirty. At the lens vs. off it.

Terms to master

Term	In one line
Shot sizes	The ladder from extreme close-up to wide shot: how much of the person is in the frame. ECU, CU, MCU, MS, MLS, LS, WS.
Camera angle	The height of the camera relative to the subject: eye level, high (looking down), or low (looking up). Each says something about them.
Canted angle	The camera rolled so the horizon runs downhill. Unease, energy, something off. Also called a Dutch angle.
Symmetry and asymmetry	A subject centered and balanced reads as formal, still, confrontational; a subject off-center on a third reads as natural and in motion.
Rule of thirds	Divide the frame into thirds both ways and put the important things on the lines or where they cross, not dead center.
Look room	Space in the frame on the side the subject is looking toward. Without it, a face looks pushed against the edge.
Over the shoulder	A shot of one person framed past the shoulder and back of head of the other. The standard way to show two people talking.
Shot / reverse shot	Two matching shots of two people talking, cut back and forth: one framed past the other's shoulder, then the mirror image from the other side.
Clean and dirty close-ups	A clean close-up has only the subject in frame. A dirty one lets a sliver of the other person (a shoulder, hair) into the edge. Same scene, two feelings.
Direct address	The subject looks into the lens and talks to the viewer: presentational. Looking off the lens, at someone beside the camera, is representational: a scene you watch.
Focal length	The distance from the lens to the sharp image when focused at infinity, in millimeters; it sets how wide or narrow the view is.
Aperture	The size of the opening in the lens, written as an f-number; wider (f/1.8) lets in more light and blurs more, narrower (f/8) lets in less and keeps more in focus.
Depth of field	The band of distances that look sharp in a photo; shallow (thin) with big sensors and wide apertures, deep with small sensors and narrow ones.

Gear: the studio cameras on tripods, a zoom and a couple of primes on the table, two chairs facing each other for the two-person shots, the OBS feed on the monitor, the capture button.

This station is about **where you put the frame**. The lens matters (part one is short), but most of what makes a shot read as a shot is framing: how much of the person, from what height, at what angle, with what around them.

Recipe

Part one: the lens, quickly.

1. **Aperture.** Focus on the subject's eyes wide open; look at the background. Close down three stops and watch it come back. Capture both.
2. **Focal length.** Wide lens, then long lens, subject framed the same size by moving the camera. Capture both. Look at the background and the shape of the face.

Part two: framing one person.

1. **Shot sizes.** Same subject, same lens, move the camera: extreme close-up (eyes and mouth), close-up (head and shoulders), medium close-up (chest up), medium (waist up), medium long (knees up), long (whole body), wide (the person small in the room). Capture each. Say the name out loud as you press the button.
2. **Angle.** Camera at eye level. Then high, looking down on them. Then low, looking up. Capture all three and look at what each does to the person.
3. **Canted.** Tilt the camera so the horizon runs downhill. Capture it. Then level it again.
4. **Symmetry and thirds.** Center the subject dead on, symmetrical, staring down the lens. Capture. Then put them on a third, looking off. Capture. Two different pictures of the same person.
5. **Look room.** Subject looking off to one side. Frame with space in front of the face; capture. Frame with the space behind the head; capture. One of these feels wrong.

Part three: two people.

1. **Shot / reverse shot.** Two people in the chairs, talking. Camera behind one person's shoulder, framing the other: an over-the-shoulder. Capture. Swap sides and frame the first person the same way. Capture. Keep the camera on the same side of the line between them so they keep looking at each other across the cut.
2. **Clean and dirty.** Reframe the close-up so the near person's shoulder is out of the frame: a clean close-up. Capture. Let a sliver of shoulder or hair back in: a dirty close-up. Capture. Same conversation, two feelings.
3. **At the lens vs. off it.** One last pair: the subject looks straight into the lens, then just off it at the person beside the camera. Presentational vs. representational.

Notice

Shot size is how close we are; angle is how we stand in relation to the person; symmetry says formal, thirds says natural; look room is where their attention goes; the OTS says there are two of them in the room. When you watch anything tonight, name the shots.